

Global study of women's experiences of premenstrual symptoms and their effects on daily life.

OBJECTIVES: To determine cross-cultural and other effects on women's experiences of premenstrual symptoms and their impact on activities of daily life (ADL). **STUDY DESIGN:** Cross-sectional survey. Sample A total of 7226 women aged 15-49 recruited by random sampling with approximately 400 each from France, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Spain, UK, Brazil, Mexico, Hong Kong, Pakistan and Thailand. Approximately 1000 women in Japan and Korea and 500 Australian women were found using Internet panels. **MAIN OUTCOME MEASURES:** Questionnaire of 23 premenstrual symptoms, sociodemographic and lifestyle variables, ADL and women's knowledge of premenstrual terms. **RESULTS:** The most prevalent symptoms were abdominal bloating, cramps or abdominal pain, irritability, mastalgia and joint/muscle/back pains. Severity of symptoms was directly proportional to duration (number of affected cycles) ($R = 0.78$). A linear model found that symptom prevalence (duration $\times$ severity) was associated with age (linear and quadratic effects), parity, current smoking and country. Premenstrual physical and mental symptom domains had similar negative effects on ADL. Impact on ADL was affected by education and exercise participation. Women's knowledge of the terms premenstrual syndrome (PMS) and premenstrual dysphoric disorder (PMDD) varied by symptom intensity, age, education and country. **CONCLUSIONS:** Four of the five most prevalent premenstrual symptoms were physical. There was a great deal of similarities of women's experiences of these symptoms across countries and regions. Women's knowledge of PMS terms is highly dependent on the country in which they live.